writes Abul Fazl, and wanted ‘to reflect’.

It was the historian who found himself continuing the journey in the emperor’s stead.

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On 5 January 1599, Abul Fazl left Agra to fetch Murad, or at least make the prince listen to Shahrukh, one of the few commanders who still remained in the Deccan with him. Murad, meanwhile, panicked at the news of the historian’s coming and decided to march back to Ahmednagar. This would give him an excuse, at least, ‘a reason for not going’ to Agra.[79]

The prince was not well. A year or so ago, his nine-year-old son Rustam had died; the final straw, it seems, on the load of Murad’s troubles. It was almost a decade since the prince had left Akbar’s court, armed with his father’s books and advice, and he had achieved nothing – winning neither Akbar’s admiration, nor the Mughal amirs’ loyalty. When his son died, Murad ‘set himself down to drink’.[80]

He got up a year later, at news of Abul Fazl’s imminent arrival, but in no state to march.

It may be that his ill health was not the result of drink and disappointment alone. Muzaffar Alam and Sanjay Subrahmanyam suggest that the Portuguese might have had a hand in it, the viceroy in Goa hoping to ‘increase internal dissensions in the Mughal camp, and draw their attention away from projects of conquest’[81] – projects that were bringing them uncomfortably close to Portuguese territory. If so, Murad’s fate is doubly tragic: the prince mourning his son and bereft of companions could not bring himself to admit defeat to his father, while the political patrons of the Father who had loved the timid boy plotted against him.

Murad did not reach Ahmednagar. He had an epileptic fit on the way and died a week later, not yet thirty years old, a grape that never ripened but only fell off the vine.

Abul Fazl, who had galloped hard to try and reach the dying prince but failed, sent the news to Akbar. No one – not even Salim – had the courage or the heart to read the whole message aloud to the emperor. It was many days later, when his mother rode down from Lahore to tell him, that Akbar learnt his Pahari jiu had died.